



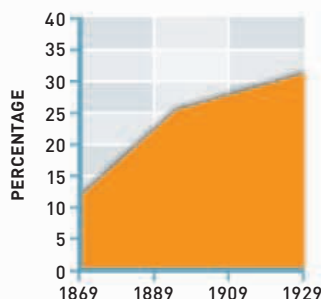
This 19th-century painting depicts Prussian hussars firing up at a French observation balloon during the Franco-Prussian War in 1870.

“THE ARMY IS THE TRUE NOBILITY OF OUR COUNTRY.”

Napoleon III, Emperor of the French

PRUSSIA'S VICTORY IN THE SEVEN WEEKS' WAR (see 1867) gave the impetus to further pursue plans for German unification, this time by bringing the southern German states into the union. Attempts had also been made to place Prince **Leopold of Hohenzollern-Sigmaringen** (1835–1905) on the Spanish throne, left vacant after Queen Isabella II's deposition in 1868 (see panel, 1872). Intense French diplomatic pressure from Napoleon III prevented this. Otto von Bismarck, the Prussian prime

minister, however, wished to provoke France into war. To these ends he published the **Ems telegram** (as it was later known), editing it to appear as though insults had been exchanged between King Wilhelm I of Prussia and the French Ambassador. France declared war on Prussia on July 19. Prussia was victorious at the battles of **Gravelotte** on August 18, and **Sedan** on September 1, where an ill Napoleon **surrendered** to German forces and was taken prisoner. While Napoleon was held captive, a provisional government for national defense was set up in Bordeaux where it was decided to depose him and establish the **Third Republic**. By mid-September, the Prussians had besieged Paris. The city was forced to surrender in early 1871 after severe food shortages. By March, an armistice had been



Immigration in Argentina

This graphic shows the steady rise in the percentage of Spanish and Italian immigrants who arrived in Argentina between 1869 and 1929.

agreed and Germany was given the regions of **Alsace** and **Lorraine**.

Meanwhile, a steady stream of **immigrants** escaping poverty and war in Europe flowed to the Americas. In the US, the **population** hit 40 million and by the end of the century it would

nearly double to 76 million. Likewise, in **Argentina** the 1870 population of 1.8 million would reach 8 million by 1914, with many immigrants from Italy and Spain—both places that had been seriously affected by years of warfare.

Siege of Paris

The siege resulted in the capture of the city by Prussian forces, leading to a humiliating French defeat in the Franco-Prussian War.



Men at their battery during the war between the Third Republic and the Paris Commune that erupted at the end of the Franco-Prussian war.



German unification

This map shows the newly unified German Empire, which was organized after Prussia's victory in the Franco-Prussian War.

KEY

- Prussian gains by 1866
- other states in North German Confederation 1867
- other German states 1866
- Austro-Hungarian empire 1867
- Prussian invasion of France in Franco-Prussian War of 1870-71
- boundary of German Empire 1871

ITALIAN TROOPS HAD ENTERED

ROME the previous September and in October a **plebiscite**, or referendum, made Rome the capital of the united Italy—which became official by 1871. The pope, however, was not pleased with his settlement offer and **excommunicated** Italian king Victor Emmanuel II, entrenching himself in the Vatican while Rome developed as the new capital. The tension between the Vatican and the Italian government would not be resolved until the 20th century.

While France and Prussia were negotiating the end of the Franco-Prussian war in 1871, angry Parisians had risen up over the surrender and established the

radical **Paris Commune**. A council of citizens—including republicans, Jacobins, socialists, and anarchists—governed Paris for over two months. The retaliation of the National Assembly, which had relocated to Versailles, was swift. Troops were sent to Paris and 20,000 people were killed.

Following victory against France, Wilhelm I of Prussia declared himself **Emperor of Germany** and named Bismarck (see 1862) as **Chancellor**.

In South Africa, a diamond rush (see 1869) in the Northern Cape was followed by the discovery of **gold** in the **Transvaal** region. This sparked the arrival of thousands of prospectors to the region.

January 2 Construction of Brooklyn bridge begins in New York (opened 1883)

June 26 Richard Wagner's *Die Walküre* (The Valkyrie) performed in Munich

July 19 Franco-Prussian War: Napoleon III (1808-73) declares war on Prussia

September 4 Third French Republic proclaimed

October 6 Rome becomes capital of unified Italy

December 30 Juan Prim (1814-70), prime minister of Spain, assassinated

Abolition of fiefs in Japan; end to feudal system

King Wilhelm I (1797-1888) of Prussia declared German emperor

March 18-May 28 Paris Commune revolt eventually suppressed by National Assembly

Gold discovered in Transvaal, northern South Africa